

ARCHITECTURE: WOMEN: OUT OF THE ARCHITECTURAL CLOSET

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ARCHITECTURE / ROBERT CAMPBELL

Women: Out of the architectural closet

A major exhibition on "Women in American Architecture" opens this week at MIT's Hayden Gallery, where it comes from its opening run at the Brooklyn Museum.

"Women in Architecture" is a poignant title because as everyone knows, there hardly are any. A 1975 study showed that only one in every 80 American registered architects was a woman. It was a ridiculously low figure even compared to such trousered enclaves as law and medicine. Even so, the few women architects were getting much less money and responsibility than men.

In the two years since that report, things may have begun to turn around. "Hero" architects, "master" plans, phallic towers are all out of fashion. Concerns long stereotyped as feminine are now "in": Preservation, the picturesque, color and clutter, participatory design. Harvard's architecture students are more than 25 percent women this year, MIT's 29 percent, the Boston Architectural Center's 16 percent.

"Women in Architecture," itself a sign of change, is best in its perception of the insane ironies that have beset the role of women in design.

The most important woman designer of the 19th Century, for example, Catherine Beecher (sister of Harriet Beecher Stowe), devoted her amazing energy to glorifying a housewifely role she refused to accept for herself.

In books and model house designs she created an image of the wire as "professional" child-raiser and homemaker that still shapes attitudes today. In our contemporary jargon, Beecher's woman was the "efficiency expert" in her kitchen "control center" using her "consumer skills" to create a home for others.

But Beecher herself never married and was much too busy writing and designing to do any homemaking

herself. Like some women architects later, she freed herself from the stereotype by helping to impose it on others.

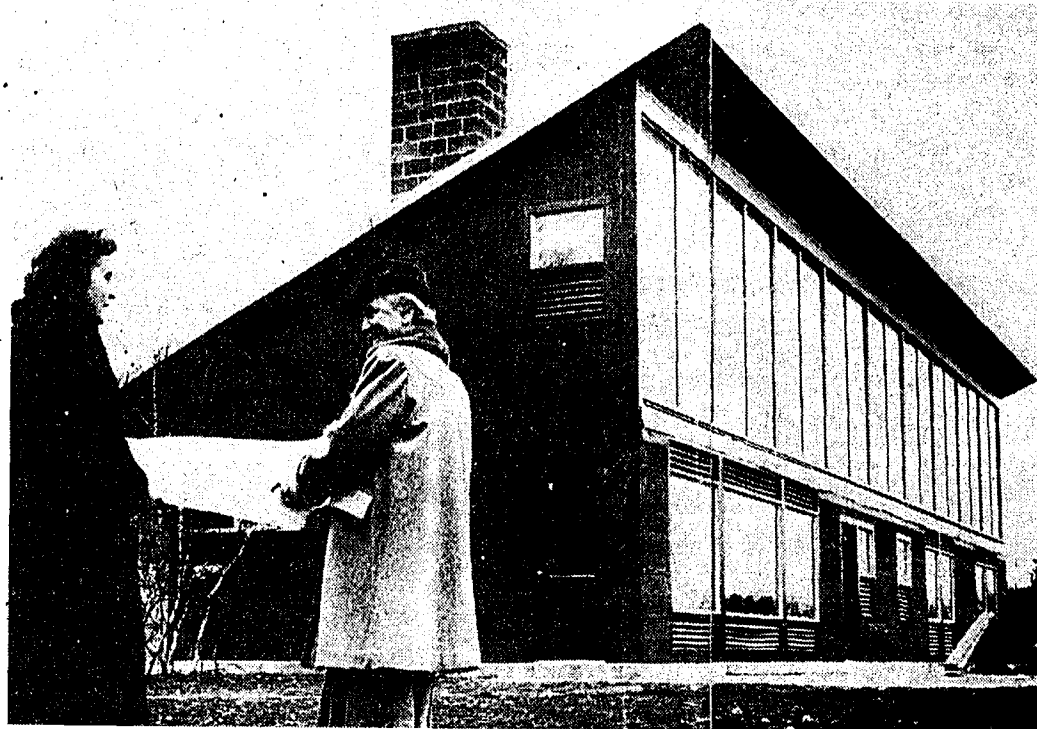
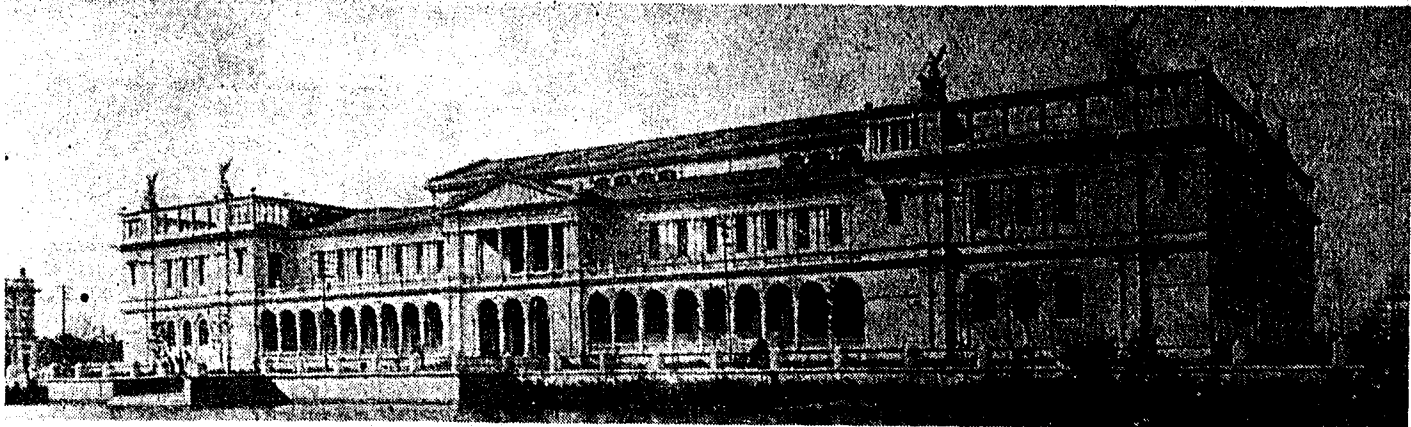
Surely no field of human activity has rationalized discrimination so blatantly as architecture. When the designer of the Women's Building at the 1893 Chicago World's Fair, Sophia Hayden, suffered a nervous breakdown, the architectural press piously wondered whether this proved women were too delicate for such a demanding profession.

Just as blacks were said to be good at rhythm and jokes, women were said to be terrific at domestic architecture, especially interior design, a patronizing attitude that helped to bar them from anything bigger.

It is truly embarrassing to read today, in the context of this exhibition, the grossly fatuous words of the great 19th Century architect Louis Sullivan. Writing admiringly about Henry Richardson's Marshal Field warehouse in Chicago Sullivan says: "Here is a man for us to look at... an entire male... four-square and brown, it stands, in physical fact, a monument to trade, to the organized commercial spirit, to the power and progress of the age... therefore have I called it, in a world of barren pettiness, a male; for it sings the song of procreant power, as the others have squealed of miscegenation."

Why have so many architects been concerned to display their masculinity? One is reminded of the reputed comment by one famous contemporary about another famous contemporary's immensely rough and strong concrete building: That it could only have been designed by a fairy truckdriver.

"Women in Architecture" tells the story of the few who made it: Julia Morgan, designer of more than 800 buildings including Hearst's San Simeon; Eleanor Raymond, pioneer in



Women's work is never done, even in architecture: Top, Sophia Hayden's Woman's Building at the 1893 Chicago World's Fair; above, Eleanor Raymond, right, who pioneered solar house in 1948 in Dover, Mass. for Amelia Peabody; and at right, Julia Morgan's San Simeon, the William Randolph Hearst castle in California.



solar heat and other technologies; Sarah Harkness, founding partner of The Architects Collaborative; Natalie Blois, anonymous co-designer of many of the best works of Skidmore, Owings and Merrill.

Yet still the stereotypes persist.

They're well summed up by Denise Scott Brown, Philadelphia planner and wife of the better known Robert Venturi, who says most people can see her in only one of two roles: Either domineering wife, or secretary.

If there's one fault to find with all

this, it's that while attacking so many sexist stereotypes, the exhibition also tries to establish some others. It hints that women have special architectural interests based on their biology, for example an interest in the relation between inside and outside, in

entrances, even in space itself as opposed to mass. This seems quite fruitless.

The exhibit has been documented in an excellent book of the same title, published by Whitney Library of Design at \$25. It opens Thursday.